

What are “fiery serpents” in the Bible?

Summary: the “fiery” adjective typically seen with the noun “serpent(s)” in the Bible seems to be primarily a descriptor of the sensation caused by the bite and not an adjective about the physical appearance of the creature itself (outside of potentially [Isa 6:2,6](#) but there is no direct connection to support that either).

First, let’s look at every usage of the Strong’s number(s) associated with “fiery serpent”. You may also need to review the context of each usage for more information. The following table is an “outline of Biblical usage” for this particular Hebrew word which reveals to us all of the Biblical definitions of a particular word or phrase in how they are used.

Search results for "H8314"

Num 21:6	And the LORD sent fiery ^{H8314} serpents among the people, and they bit the people; and much people of Israel died.
Num 21:8	And the LORD said unto Moses, Make thee a fiery serpent ^{H8314} , and set it upon a pole: and it shall come to pass, that every one that is bitten, when he looketh upon it, shall live.
Deu 8:15	Who led thee through that great and terrible wilderness, wherein were fiery ^{H8314} serpents, and scorpions, and drought, where there was no water; who brought thee forth water out of the rock of flint;
Isa 6:2	Above it stood the seraphims ^{H8314} : each one had six wings; with twain he covered his face, and with twain he covered his feet, and with twain he did fly.
Isa 6:6	Then flew one of the seraphims ^{H8314} unto me, having a live coal in his hand, which he had taken with the tongs from off the altar:
Isa 14:29	Rejoice not thou, whole Palestina, because the rod of him that smote thee is broken: for out of the serpent's root shall come forth a cockatrice (Jer 8:17), and his fruit shall be a fiery ^{H8314} flying serpent ^{H8314} .
Isa 30:6	The burden of the beasts of the south: into the land of trouble and anguish, from whence come the young and old lion, the viper and fiery ^{H8314} flying serpent ^{H8314} , they will carry their riches upon the shoulders of young asses, and their treasures upon the bunches of camels, to a people that shall not profit them.

Note that “seraphim” is the plural of “seraph”. An “im” suffix in the Bible is often, but not always, an indicator of a plurality and is sometimes, but not always, accompanied with an “s” suffix:

- Elohim (Hebrew name for the Godhead: The Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost)
- Anakims (children of Anak), Emims, and the Horims
- Philistim (Philistines)
- Descendants of Mizraim (probably only a man’s name, not plural) [Egyptians] the son of Ham:
 - Ludim/Lydians
 - Naphtuhim
 - Anamim
 - Lehabim
- Lubims (descendants of Put/Phut the son of Ham; AKA Libyans)
- Dodanim (descendants of Javan [Grecia/Greece] the son of Japheth)
- Valley of Charashim (valley of [plural] craftsman; [1Ch 4:14](#), [Neh 11:35](#))

H8314 שָׂרָף Pronunciation: sârâph saw-rawf' Derivation: from שָׂרַף; (H8313) Strong's: burning, i.e. (figuratively) poisonous (serpent); specifically, a saraph or symbolical creature (from their copper color) KJV: fiery (serpent), seraph.
H8313 שָׂרַף Pronunciation: sâraph saw-raf' Derivation: a primitive root; Strong's: to be (causatively, set) on fire KJV: (cause to, make a) burn((-ing), up) kindle, [idiom] utterly.

H8313 appears 117 times in the King James Bible and 112 times (or 96%) of those are one of the following: burn (39), burned (33), burneth (4), burnt (36).

A search on the world wide web for “which venomous snake bites create a burning sensation and are native to Israel and the Sinai peninsula” reveals the following:

There are only two known species of snakes native to Israel and the Sinai Peninsula whose venom causes an intense burning sensation by activating the TRPV1 pain receptors in humans (that is also activated by temperatures over 43°C, capsaicin, acidic pH, and inflammatory mediators such as cytokines, prostaglandins, histamine, kinins, and leukotrienes).

One of those snake species is called the “Painted saw-scaled viper” ([Echis coloratus](#)) but the other which is called the “Israeli mole viper” ([Atractaspis engaddensis](#)) is of particular interest because of the following:

- It's modern Hebrew name is "**Saraf** Ein Gedi" (see definitions for H8314 and H8313 above).
 - The modern Hebrew definition of “Saraf” is “burning or venomous serpent”.
- Even at high concentrations it's venom does not block contractions of skeletal muscles: In other words, after being bitten, you are still able to move your neck muscles and for example ... look at a brass serpent on a pole.
 - In God's instructions in [Numbers 21:9](#) the person was to look at the brass serpent *after* they were bitten. This would not normally be possible if the venom interfered with or prevented muscle movement (which is typical for highly venomous snake bites).
- It is categorized as having “**very high** lethal potency” with an i.v. LD50 of 0.06-0.075 micro-grams per gram of body weight in mice. The venom's varied and nasty effects begin [within minutes](#) in humans.
 - It's venom is 29 times more potent than a member of the same family the Dahomey burrowing asp ([Atractaspis dahomeyensis](#)) and 36 to 45 times more potent than the [western diamondback rattlesnake](#) on the lowest end (intravenous injection).
- There is currently **no antivenom** available for this snakes venom.
- We are still unsure of exactly how the venom kills a person (“seemingly [from] neurotoxic effects”) and reports of people surviving bites are actually more common than reports of deaths (apparently due to those being reported having the fangs of the snake not penetrating deep enough into the skin).
- In an [Israeli news article from 2022-08-19](#) it is described as “He is the most venomous snake in Israel”.
 - The heart of the 3 year old that was bitten stopped beating, among other complications, and needless to say without swift medical assistance she would have quickly died.
- Based on the evidence, if the snake gets a good, deep bite on you, and someone isn't around to keep your heart pumping you would likely die within minutes (you will very likely be unconscious within minutes regardless).

Without CPR and other methods of restarting the heart, chemical injections, and machine assistance there is no defense against the deadly venom – except if God intervenes. Putting all of this together this species seems to be a very likely candidate for the same species of serpent that we read about in [Numbers 21](#).

References to “fiery” in the Bible that indicate a fire as in a flame are not ever directly associated with H8314 and there is no other direct connection that would indicate to us that is what is meant:

Search results for “fiery” sans H8314
(looking for back-references/reciprocals to H8314)

Deu 33:2	And he said, The LORD came from Sinai, and rose up from Seir unto them; he shined forth from mount Paran, and he came with ten thousands of saints: from his right hand <i>went a fiery</i> ^{H799 H784} law for them.
Psa 21:9	Thou shalt make them as a <i>fiery</i> ^{H784} oven ^{H8574} in the time of thine anger: the LORD shall swallow them up in his wrath, and the fire shall devour them.
Dan 3:6	And whoso falleth not down and worshippeth shall the same hour be cast into the midst of a burning <i>fiery</i> ^{H5135} furnace ^{H861} .
Dan 3:11	And whoso falleth not down and worshippeth, <i>that</i> he should be cast into the midst of a burning ^{H3345} <i>fiery</i> ^{H5135} furnace ^{H861} .
Dan 3:15	Now if ye be ready that at what time ye hear the sound of the cornet, flute, harp, sackbut, psaltery, and dulcimer, and all kinds of musick, ye fall down and worship the image which I have made; <i>well</i> : but if ye worship not, ye shall be cast the same hour into the midst of a burning ^{H3345} <i>fiery</i> ^{H5135} furnace ^{H861} ; and who <i>is</i> that God that shall deliver you out of my hands?
Dan 3:17	If it be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning ^{H3345} <i>fiery</i> ^{H5135} furnace ^{H861} , and he will deliver <i>us</i> out of thine hand, O king.
Dan 3:20	And he commanded the most mighty men that <i>were</i> in his army to bind Shadrach, Meshach, and Abed-nego, <i>and</i> to cast <i>them</i> into the burning ^{H3345} <i>fiery</i> ^{H5135} furnace ^{H861} .
Dan 3:21	Then these men were bound in their coats, their hosen, and their hats, and their <i>other</i> garments, and were cast into the midst of the burning ^{H3345} <i>fiery</i> ^{H5135} furnace ^{H861} .
Dan 3:23	And these three men, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abed-nego, fell down bound into the midst of the burning ^{H3345} <i>fiery</i> ^{H5135} furnace ^{H861} .
Dan 3:26	¶ Then Nebuchadnezzar came near to the mouth of the burning ^{H3345} <i>fiery</i> ^{H5135} furnace ^{H861} , <i>and</i> spake, and said, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abed-nego, ye servants of the most high God, come forth, and come <i>hither</i> . Then Shadrach, Meshach, and Abed-nego, came forth of the midst of the fire.
Dan 7:9	¶ I beheld till the thrones were cast down, and the Ancient of days did sit, whose garment was white as snow, and the hair of his head like the pure wool: his throne <i>was like</i> the <i>fiery</i> ^{H5135} flame ^{H7631} , <i>and</i> his wheels as burning ^{H1815} fire ^{H5135} .
Dan 7:10	A <i>fiery</i> ^{H5135} stream issued and came forth from before him: thousand thousands ministered unto him, and ten thousand times ten thousand stood before him: the judgment was set, and the books were opened.
Eph 6:16	Above all, taking the shield of faith, wherewith ye shall be able to quench all the <i>fiery</i> ^{G4448} darts of the wicked.
Heb 10:27	But a certain fearful looking for of judgment and <i>fiery</i> ^{G4442} indignation, which shall devour the adversaries.
1Pe 4:12	Beloved, think it not strange concerning the <i>fiery</i> ^{G4451} trial which is to try you, as though some strange thing happened unto you:

- Hebrew equivalents to G4442:
 - H217, H784, H1200, H3827, H3852, H5135, H7565, H8316
- G4451 is derived from H3925 (diligently, expert, instruct(ed), learn, skilful, taught, teach(ers|est|eth|ing))

- Hebrew equivalents to G4442:
 - H119, H977, H6884, H8443

H8316 (burnt, burned, burning) is also derived from the same root word H8313 (the same root word for H8314). This does not indicate an equivalent connection but it is merely one way to search for those that might exist. Other than that, no other back-references exist (significant or otherwise).